



▲ THREE-EAVED STRUCTURE OF THE HALL OF PRAYER FOR GOOD HARVEST AT THE TEMPLE OF HEAVEN

Temple of Heaven

Location Beijing, China

The potency and reach of Ming China (1368–1644) are encapsulated by the buildings of the Temple of Heaven. Many of them were constructed under the original builder of the Forbidden City, the Emperor Yongle, in 1420. The complex covers a site of 1 square mile (2.6 square km). There are three principal structures, all arranged on an exact north–south axis, and all, as symbols of the sky, are circular. The site itself is rectilinear—a symbol of Earth. The Altar of Heaven, built in 1530, is an open platform made of three levels of white marble. The Imperial Vault of Heaven, which was rebuilt in 1752, is a single-eaved building with

a blue-tiled roof. The three-eaved Hall of Prayer for Good Harvest is the most important of the buildings. Its interior is an expanse of dazzlingly detailed, symbolically charged decorations.

Tomb of Humayun

Location Delhi, India

The Tomb of Humayun, completed in 1566, commemorates the second of India's Mughal emperors. Heavily influenced by Persian architecture in style, the building displays the balance, refinement, and symmetry that would become the defining characteristics of Mughal architecture. Also influenced by Persia is the garden in which the tomb sits—it exudes courtly sophistication, with its precise planting and well-defined

waterways. It was intended to be an earthly representation of the Gardens of Paradise. The three-story tomb consists of a multiarched base, above which rises a much larger, three-bay second story with angled corners. This is dominated by a central pointed arch with an apselike interior that leads on to further arches. On top of the building sits a white marble dome, 140 ft (42.5 m) high, flanked and fronted by kiosks.

Fatehpur Sikri

Location Uttar Pradesh, India

Akbar, the third and greatest of India's Mughal emperors, had an energetic interest in the arts, which received a huge boost under his rule. Among his

ambitious projects was an entirely new capital, Fatehpur Sikri, constructed from 1569 and largely complete by 1585. However, by 1610, it had been abandoned, possibly because of inadequate water supplies or simply because Akbar had lost interest in it. Nevertheless, it remains among the most sumptuous and startling of Mughal achievements. Its red sandstone courtyards, palaces, arcades, towers, and domes are richly ornamented. Among the highlights are the vast Buland Darwaza, the principal entrance to the mosque courtyard; the mosque itself, the Jama Mosque; and the shimmering white marble tomb of the Sufi mystic Sheikh Salim Chishti.

Pavilion of Ali Qapu

Location Isfahan, Iran

The Pavilion or Palace of Ali Qapu (*Ali* meaning “exalted” or “great” and *Qapu* meaning “gate”) was part of the ambitious works launched by the Safavid emperor Shah Abbas I. Built in the early 17th century, it overlooks the Meidan Emam, a public square larger than any in Europe. Externally, its most obvious feature is the lofty terrace, or *talar*, supported by tapering columns. However, the building's real glories are inside. The Ali Qapu had no real function, other than as a kind of pleasure palace, and this is reflected in its decorations. Produced under the direction of the shah's court painter, Reza Abbasi, they are supremely refined. For example, the Music Room on the sixth floor has decoration piled on soaring decoration.

Beehive Village

Location Aleppo, Syria

The conical beehive houses of northern Syria (see p.10) represent a remarkable survival